Sripada Yamunacharya

Yamunacharya (Alavandar) · @yamunacharya

Grandson of Nathamuni

Yamunacharya, also called Alavandar, was the chief exponent of Sri Vaishnavism between Nathamuni and Ramanuja and Ramanuja's direct spiritual forerunner. He was Nathamuni's grandson. Nathamuni's son, Ishvaramuni, died young while his wife was expecting a child, and that child became Yamunacharya; Nathamuni himself, having lost his son, took sannyasa.

Yamuna was born about 953 in Madura, chief city of the Pandya kingdom.[1] His father was no longer living and his grandfather had entered sannyasa, so the boy grew up with his mother and grandmother. An orphan, he studied brilliantly and surpassed all his peers. His teacher, Sri Bhashyacharya, loved him for his diligence, and his companions for his gentle nature and beauty.

The Victor

In those years the king's court pandita, nicknamed Vidvajjana-kolahala, “he who throws the learned into confusion,” exacted a yearly tribute from the panditas of the land, and those who did not pay he defeated in debate, shamed and punished.[2] Once his disciple came to collect the tribute at Bhashyacharya's ashrama, but did not find the teacher there. Twelve-year-old Yamuna, regarding such a demand as an insult to his guru, refused to pay and sent word that “a lowly follower of Bhashyacharya” challenged the all-conquering pandita to open debate. The pandita, a favourite of the generous king, to whom everyone paid rather than risk their name as scholars, only laughed: “Very well, call this scholar here.”

By royal order a day was fixed, and the boy was carried to court in a rich palanquin. The queen, charmed by his beauty, took his side, the king that of his pandita, and they made a wager: if the pandita won, the queen would submit to the king in everything; if the boy won, he would receive half the kingdom.

The pandita began with fine points of grammar, and Yamuna answered flawlessly. Then Yamuna put forward three statements and invited him to refute them: “Your mother is no barren woman,” “The king is righteous,” “The queen is chaste.” The pandita was silent, and then accused the boy of treason and blasphemy. So Yamuna refuted them himself, from the “Manu-smriti” with the commentary of Medhatithi. “To have one son is as good as to have none,” people say (9.61), and the pandita's mother had borne only one son. A king who protects his subjects receives a sixth part of their piety, and one who does not protect them a sixth part of their impiety (8.304); and in the age of Kali people are impious. When it came to the queen, all fell silent and she coloured: how could the boy get out of this without putting her to shame? But here too he appealed to Manu: the king stands for the gods, and within him abide Agni, Vayu, Surya, Chandra, Yama, Varuna, Kuvera and Indra — so the queen's husband is not one alone.

The queen embraced the boy and called him “Alabandaru,” “the victor.” The king, addressing “Alabandaru, child-scholar,” delivered the defeated pandita into his power and, keeping the wager, humbly begged him to take half the realm: those lands are still called Alavandara-medu.

King and Monk

So Yamuna became the “boy-king” Alabandaru. Over the years he became ever more absorbed in affairs of state and nearly forgot his grandfather's legacy: amid royal luxury and power little time remained for the spiritual.

But Nathamuni, who left the world at about that time, had before his departure charged his closest disciple Nambi to inspire his grandson to leave the kingdom and lead the Sri Vaishnavas, for no one but he could take Nathamuni's place.[3] Years later Nambi came to the palace, but the beggar-monk was not admitted. So he began bringing the royal cook the greens called “tuduvalai,” which were said to purify the mind and incline it to contemplation; the devout cook saw what a treasure they were, and the king came to relish them. One day Nambi did not bring them, and the king, learning of the mysterious sadhu, had him brought in and asked why he supplied the greens without asking anything.

Nambi asked to speak without witnesses; the king sent his servants away and gave his guest a seat. Alone with him, Nambi told how his grandfather had passed away and of his concern: the sampradaya needed a learned defender, able to overcome rival schools and uphold the principles of the tradition, while the grandson had become a king attached to luxury. After conversations with Nambi on the “Bhagavad-gita,” Yamunacharya came to the temple of Srirangam, received the mantra from Nambi and, renouncing royal wealth, dedicated himself to his grandfather's work.

Acharya of Srirangam

Giving himself to austerity, contemplation and devotion, Yamunacharya soon became the foremost thinker and spiritual guide of the Sri Vaishnavas, renowned for the depth of his realization and his learning. He united Nathamuni's teaching with Vedic worship according to the Pancharatra. His unquestioned brahminhood helped establish the Pancharatrika Vedanta against the protests of Shankara's followers; thus he raised the prestige of Vaishnavism and of devotion to Krishna, showing their basis in scripture and their superiority to worldly caste pride.

He left the prayers to Vishnu called the “Stotra-ratna” (“Jewel of Prayers”), the “Gita-sangraha,” a view of the “Bhagavad-gita,” the “Agama-pramanya,” which unites the Pancharatra with Vaishnava Vedanta, the “Siddhi-traya,” of which only fragments survive, and the “Atma-siddhi.” He wrote mostly in Sanskrit, departing from the Tamil tradition of the Alvars, in order to cast the southern tradition in a classical form intelligible to Vedic scholars; thereby he prepared the ground for the recognition of Sri Vaishnavism as an orthodox sampradaya. Later, at Srirangam, Ramanuja was taught from the “Gitartha-sangraha” and the “Siddhi-traya.”

Alavandar lived at the temple of Srirangam and directed the service of Ranganatha — a service later headed by Ramanuja and Sudarshanacharya.[4] He had many disciples, and history has kept the names of twenty; all were sincere and devoted, but none had the learning and strength to carry on his work. His favourite disciple was Periya Tirumalai Nambi (Sri Shaila Purna), who took sannyasa under his guidance and served him to the end — Ramanuja's maternal uncle. Kanchipurna, who was not a brahmana by birth, and Mahapurna were also disciples of Yamunacharya.

Yamunacharya and Ramanuja

The story of how Yamunacharya and Ramanuja met — and did not meet — is told in detail in the article on Ramanuja; here, in brief. Yamunacharya once came to Kanchi himself to see the young Ramanuja, but, finding him a pupil of Yadava Prakasha, kept his distance; tradition says that he only prayed from afar that the youth would become the establisher of the teaching (darshana-pravartaka) of the Sri sampradaya.

Very old, ill and near death, Yamunacharya learned that Ramanuja had left Yadava Prakasha and was serving Kanchipurna, and sent his disciples to fetch him. Ramanuja hastened to Srirangam, but was too late: Yamunacharya had departed for Vaikuntha, to the eternal service of Vishnu.[5] Three fingers of his right hand were clenched — never before, his disciples said, had he held his hand so; these were three unfulfilled wishes. When Ramanuja made three vows — to open to the people the path of surrender to

Vishnu through the pancha-samskara, to expound the Alvars' hymns, and to write a commentary on the Vedanta-sutras — the fingers opened one after another, and the teacher's face shone with peace, as though he could now go untroubled, his work being in safe keeping. From then on the biography calls Yamunacharya Ramanuja's divine teacher.

After his departure his disciples at Srirangam called Ramanuja to lead them, and when Ramanuja faced his debate with Yajnamurti, the Deity Varada told him in a dream to follow the arguments of Yamunacharya. The general shape of Sri Vaishnavism and many of its details had been outlined by Yamunacharya; it remained for Ramanuja to complete and establish what had been begun. So it was Ramanuja who fulfilled Yamunacharya's hopes.

Yamunacharya's Prayers among the Gaudiya Vaishnavas

His “Stotra-ratna” is treasured by the followers of Sri Chaitanya as well. When Rupa and Sanatana first came to the Lord at Ramakeli, straws between their teeth, they begged for His mercy in Yamunacharya's words: “O Lord, let me confess what fills my heart. My supreme appeal to Your mercy holds not a trace of deceit. For if You do not bestow it on me, it will be hard for You to find anyone more fit for it” — and again: “Unceasing service to God carries away all worldly desires and gives peace to the soul. When shall I become Your eternal servant? When shall I rejoice at having found You as my Master forever?” (CC, Madhya 1.203, 1.206).[6] Ramananda Raya cited the same verse to the Lord when speaking of service to Him as Master (Madhya 8.73). Shivananda Sena, meeting the Lord in Puri, fell before Him in a surge of love and recited a stanza of Yamunacharya: “O Lord, having lost count of time, I was sinking in the bottomless, boundless ocean of material existence, and now at last I have reached the shore — I have found You, my Deity. And in me You have at last found one who needs Your mercy more than any other” (Madhya 11.151); Kavi Karnapura describes the same scene in the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya” (8.41).

Thus in Yamunacharya's words the Gaudiya Vaishnavas voice sharanagati, self-surrender to the Lord: complete humility, the confession of one's need for mercy, and the single desire to become His eternal servant. Krishnadasa Kaviraja Gosvami uses his stanzas to explain why people of demoniac nature do not see the Lord, while His pure devotees always see Him, however He may hide (Adi 3.86, 3.88; Antya 3.91). And his verse on Ananta Shesha, who for the Lord's service becomes His dwelling, bed, throne, sandals, garments, pillow and umbrella, Vrindavana Dasa Thakura and Karnapura apply to Sri Nityananda (“Chaitanya-bhagavata,” Adi 1.46; “Chaitanya-chandrodaya” 3.45).

Yamunacharya and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta

In 1898 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati wrote in the “Sajjana-toshani” about Sri Nathamuni, Yamunacharya and other acharyas of the Sri sampradaya. He also names Yamunacharya and Ramanujacharya among the acharyas who, refuting Mayavada, preached Vishnu-bhakti to the world: they relied on the reasoning of the sage Bodhayana, as Nimbarka relied on Audulomi, Madhva on Vyasa, and Vishnusvami on Rudra. His disciple Nisikanta Sanyal counts Yamunacharya among the “stars of the first magnitude” of the South, together with Shathakopa, Ramanuja, Vishnusvami and Madhva, and writes that Ramanuja accepted sannyasa on the bank of the Anantasaras at Kanchi, calling on the grace of Sri Yamunacharya.

1. Our calendar does not list Yamunacharya's appearance day; the biography gives only the year.

2. According to the biography, this was “the Pandya king of the Cholas”; so in the text.

3. This Nambi, a disciple of Nathamuni, is not to be confused with Periya Tirumalai Nambi, a disciple of Yamunacharya himself.

4. In two biographies that list the saints of Srirangam, Alavandar (Alabandaru) is named separately from Yamunacharya — in one among the kings who lived at the temple, in the other as a rishi; the two are said to be one person in one of them, in

the account of the debate.

5. The biography does not give the year or day of Yamunacharya's departure; our calendar does not list it.

6. The stanza numbers of the “Stotra-ratna” (47, 43, 21, 12, 13) are those given in our translation of the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”; the verse on Ananta Shesha is 37 or 40, depending on the edition: the numbering differs between editions.